Édouard turned to Léa. “That boy is always hungry!” He slid the leather handles of a large wicker basket over his shoulders, and she followed him up the slope to the rows of vines. He stopped and put the basket down, pointing to the grapes dangling from thin shoots.

“Colors are key when picking—deep browns, yellow, transparent green. If you don’t find those colors, leave them on the vine for the third pass.” He wiped his forehead. “I used to harvest thrice. Now, with only André helping, I’m lucky to make two passes. But with this fine weather, the bright green ones can stay on the vines until early October. It will give them more time to ripen.”

He walked to an adjacent row, cupping a cluster of clear grapes with a madder hue. “This color signifies a high alcohol concentration, giving the wine a rich taste. I don’t want all the grapes like this, but a small amount is perfect.”

He took a few steps farther along the row. “Now, do you see the dark brown lines running over these grapes?”

“The color is more like mustard than green,” Léa said.

“We jokingly call those lines *le poil de lièvre*, the coat of the hare, because it resembles the stripes on a hare’s fur. Pick them—they give a unique flavor.”

Léa nodded.

“Finally, never pick bright green grapes; they must always have a yellow tint. If you find one side of the cluster bright green and the other yellow, leave them to ripen more. That’s it.” He paused to look at her. “Any questions?”

“So, I fill the basket—”

“Yes, drag it along the grass as you pick, but be careful not to damage the vine. We’ll need cuttings for next year.”

All morning, Léa picked grape clusters and put them in the basket. Monsieur LeBlanc stayed nearby, checking occasionally to make sure she chose the right ones. Sweat rolled down her back, and her legs ached from standing and bending to clip grapes. But the work wasn’t hard, and it distracted her from their money troubles and worrying about where they’d live in October.

“Lunch,” a woman called out.

Monsieur LeBlanc motioned that Léa should follow him to an open